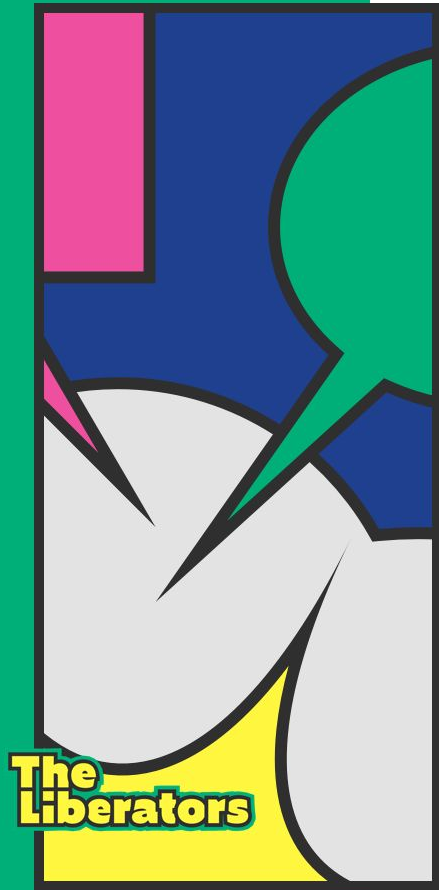
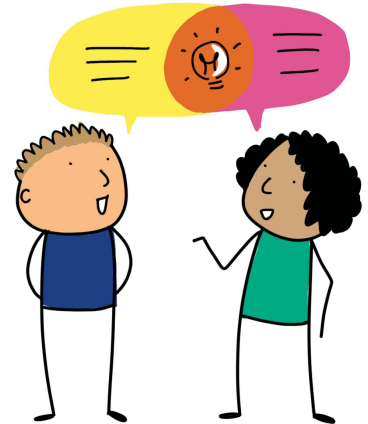




Liberating Structures: 1-2-4-ALL

A collection of practical tips, tweaks, and resources



Liberating Structures were developed by Henri Lipmanowicz and Keith McCandless. The foundational Liberating Structures materials are shared under a Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 license (CC BY-SA 4.0).

These Practice Guides build on their work and combine it with our own experiences, illustrations, and practical tips.



Introduction

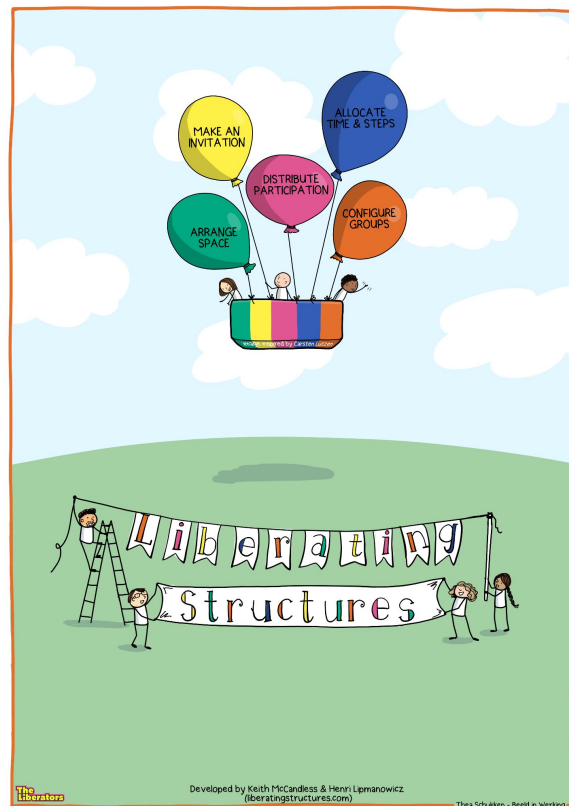
For almost a decade, Liberating Structures have been an important part of my facilitation toolkit. Over the years, I've created my own materials, enjoyed using those created by others, picked up countless practical tips, and discovered many useful tweaks.

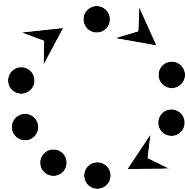
Until now, all of these were scattered across different places, often leaving me searching for that one illustration, idea, or tip when I needed it most. So I decided to bring everything together in one place, with a separate guide for each Liberating Structure. And yes, it definitely satisfies my inner facilitation nerd. 🤓

I'm creating these guides mostly for myself, and they'll probably never be finished. I keep learning, experimenting, and discovering new things. But since sharing freely with the community is an important part of what we do, I'll also make them available through [our public GitHub repository](#).

I hope you'll find something useful in them too. Enjoy!

[Barry Overeem](#)





About 1-2-4-ALL

1-2-4-ALL is one of the most widely used Liberating Structures, and for good reason. In just 12 minutes, it engages everyone simultaneously in generating ideas, questions, and suggestions.

Participants first reflect individually, then exchange ideas in pairs, develop them further in foursomes, and finally share with the whole group. This simple sequence gives every voice room, including ideas and perspectives that might otherwise remain unspoken. It also helps diminish power differences by giving everyone an equal opportunity to contribute.

The structure works equally well with small and large groups. We've used it with groups as small as four, with twelve participants in workshops, and with more than a hundred people at conferences. Moving through the different steps creates a broad range of perspectives while tapping into the collective knowledge of the group.

It's simple, fast, and remarkably versatile. And because the ideas come from the participants themselves, there's often more shared ownership of both the ideas and whatever happens next.

1 - 2 - 4 - ALL

Engage everyone simultaneously in generating questions, ideas, and suggestions



Illustration we created
with [Thea Schukken](#)

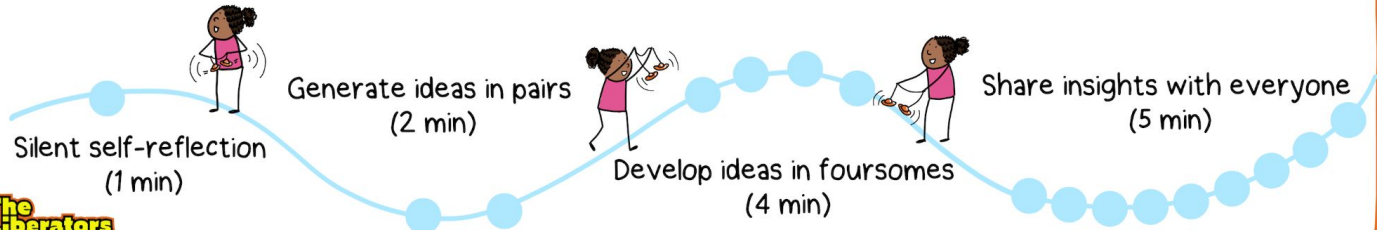


Illustration we created
with [Thea Schukken](#)

1-2-4-All



Engage everyone simultaneously in generating questions, ideas, and suggestions



(~12 min)

*Let's think about our shared challenge
and generate ideas to address it.*

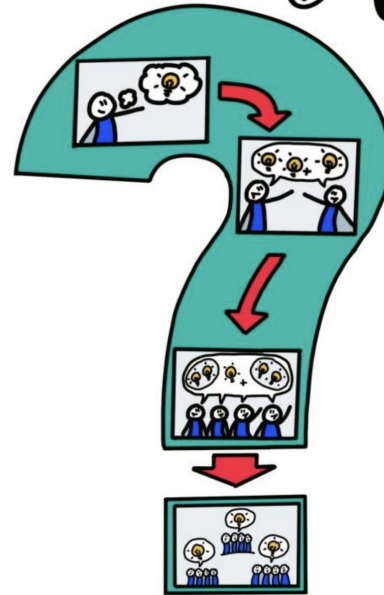
What opportunities do you see for moving forward?



- 1 Share the invitation and identify the shared challenge.
- 2 Individually, everyone silently reflects and writes down ideas and actions. (1 min)
- 3 In pairs, participants share and develop their ideas. (2 min)
- 4 In quartets, participants share and develop their ideas further. Notice similarities and differences. (4 min)
- 5 Everyone returns to plenary. A few people share something they think everyone should hear. (5 min)

Illustration by
[Linda van Sinten](#)

1-2-4 All



ENGAGE EVERYONE SIMULTANEOUSLY IN GENERATING
QUESTIONS, IDEAS AND SUGGESTIONS



Tips, tweaks, and thoughts

- Don't skip or rush the one-minute individual reflection. Some people are often (too) eager to start talking, while others really need that quiet time to gather their thoughts.
- Invite everyone to write down their ideas during the individual reflection.
- Be strict with the timing. Short rounds create energy and prevent conversations from drifting.
- At the same time, be flexible with the timing. Use your gut feeling to decide when to stick to the timeboxes and when to extend them. Sometimes be strict, sometimes be flexible.
- Consider not using a visual timer. It can distract from the conversation, make the structure feel overly mechanical, and create unnecessary pressure.
- Play Bingo during the All round. Invite each group of four to call out "Bingo!" when another group shares an idea they also discussed. Groups can only contribute something new that hasn't been mentioned yet. This helps avoid repetition and keeps the All round focused.



Tips, tweaks, and thoughts

- When the group size doesn't divide neatly, invite someone to become an observer. Afterwards, ask what they noticed.
- During the "All" step, ask: "What have you heard in your small group that is worth sharing with everyone else?" Asking what they heard, rather than what they said, encourages participants to build on each other's ideas rather than repeat their own.
- Consider occasionally skipping the "All" step. Not every conversation needs a plenary harvest.
- Encourage self-organization. Once participants have experienced 1-2-4-ALL, you don't always need to facilitate every step. Give them 10–12 minutes and let them organize the process themselves.
- Pay attention to the question. 1-2-4-ALL is only as good as the invitation you give people. A vague question usually produces vague conversations.



Online tips & tweaks

- Keep the invitation visible. Put the question in the chat before opening the breakout rooms, so participants can easily find it again.
- Keep instructions for breakout rooms minimal. Participants should spend their limited time talking, not figuring out what they're supposed to do.
- If possible, keep pairs together when moving from "2" to "4". This preserves the natural build-up of the conversation.
- Consider using 1-3-ALL online. Creating pairs and then merging them into foursomes can be technically cumbersome. Going directly from individual reflection to trios often works surprisingly well.
- Use the chat for the "ALL". Invite everyone to type one important insight but wait before pressing Enter. Then have everyone post simultaneously. This keeps the "ALL" fast and gives every group a voice.
- Invite participants to turn their camera's off for the 1-minute reflection. When they're ready, turn it back on. This gives the facilitator a subtle visual cue of when people are ready to continue, without interrupting the reflection or repeatedly asking, "Does everyone need more time?"

Interested in learning more?

Articles about 1-2-4-ALL:

- [Our thoughts](#) on this Liberating Structure
- [The official description](#) of 1-2-4-ALL

Looking for (even) more inspiration?

- Check the resources on [the Liberating Structures website](#)
- Check [our blog](#) with 100+ articles
- Browse our public [GitHub repository](#) with illustrations, DIY workshops, templates, papers, and other free resources.
- [Webshop](#) with Linda van Sinten's illustrations
- Join our public [online or in-person meetups](#)

Interested in collaborating?

- Check [my workshop offerings](#).
- I'm available as a trainer or facilitator for meetings, workshops, and other gatherings.
- Whether you want to learn Liberating Structures or use them to tackle a real challenge, I'd be happy to help.

Get in touch: barry.overeem@theliberators.com



A stylized graphic featuring a rainbow with orange, pink, and white bands, set against a blue background. The rainbow is curved and appears to be part of a larger, abstract design. The center of the image is a bright yellow area.

The Liberators

Unleashing Organisational Superpowers